

are looking for hostess gifts, just because presents, political contributions, birthday ideas for children, or a romantic anniversary. The important thing is to stick to your agreed-upon range, whether it's \$5, \$50, or more.

10. Pick a pet charity

Or two. Or three. The point is, having a set location where you channel your charitable gifting monies can not only help you determine a specific amount to contribute according to your budget, but it also gives you a framework to refer to and rely on when those unexpected solicitation calls come in. Politely declining yet stating that you've already given to a charity you've chosen to consistently support can often get them off the line. If they ask for your support as well and you really feel you want to but can't afford to write a check, consider other efforts you can contribute to for their cause. Offer to write about them on your blog or reach out to others you think may be able to donate. If they don't appreciate your efforts, then you've at least made an effort you can be proud of.

11. Have some fun at it

If you are looking for a budget option to go out on a dinner date with

your partner, and someone is hosting one of the fund-raising variety, why not get a two-fer? Other options are out there for this as well, including shopping for items you were going to need anyway that give proceeds to a particular worthy cause. If it's within your budget, and you were going to anyway, why not? — **Myscha Theriault**

10 Easy Ways to Find Money for Charity

When my husband and I both worked, I was into instant-gratification charity. I remember reading the newspaper at my desk one morning and seeing a child the same age as my daughter on the front page. My daughter was a healthy toddler, but this little girl was emaciated, no bigger than an infant, and could not lift her head.

She was in Sudan, so I logged right onto www.UNICEF.org from my office computer and made a credit card donation. If I donated my take-home pay from that one day, I could then